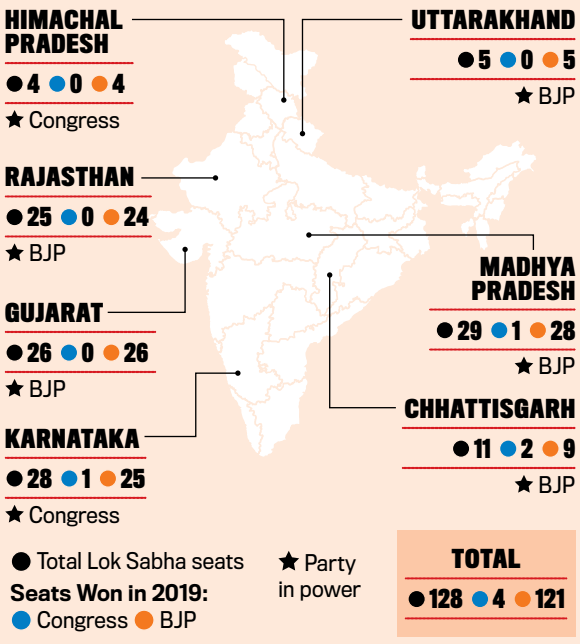
WHY CONGRESS MUST DELIVER

IN THESE SEVEN STATES, ACCOUNTING FOR 128 SEATS, THE CONGRESS IS THE MAIN RIVAL TO THE BJP (OTHER I.N.D.I.A. ALLIES HAVE LITTLE PRESENCE). FOR THE ALLIANCE, IT IS CRUCIAL THAT THE CONGRESS UPS ITS TALLY MANIFOLD HERE FROM THE DISMAL FOUR SEATS NOW



THE INDIA BLOC ALLIES FEEL THAT HAD THE CONGRESS BEEN MORE ACCOMMODATIVE, THE RESULTS IN THE HEARTLAND STATES MAY HAVE BEEN DIFFERENT. IN THE END, THE ALLIES CONTESTED 92 SEATS IN MP

it," he said. The SP even skipped a meeting of INDIA's floor leaders that Kharge, who is also the leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha, convened on December 5.

At that meeting, TMC leader Derek O'Brien asked the Congress leadership to fast-track the seat-sharing discussion, a day after Mamata raised the issue during her speech in the state assembly. Both Akhilesh and Mamata also asserted that the margin of Congress defeats could have been smaller, or even turned to victories, had it agreed to share seats. Together, the SP, JD(U) and Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) contested 92 seats in MP.

And while Mamata may be batting for discussions on seat-sharing, her party is itself unwilling to walk the talk. It's no secret that there is no love lost between the TMC and the Left parties; Trinamool has made it clear it won't join hands with the Congress or the Left in Bengal. The Congress state unit is not ready to cede any ground to Trinamool either. State Congress president Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury, a bitter rival of Mamata's, seldom misses an opportunity to take potshots at the chief minister.

Meanwhile, the Arvind Kejriwal-led AAP has indicated that it is unlikely to share seats with the Congress in Delhi and Punjab, where they are in power. The recent polls have left the Congress with only one state—Himachal Pradesh—in north India, prompting AAP to lay claim to being the "largest Opposition party" in the region. Jammu and Kashmir National Conference (NC) leader Omar Abdullah has also said that his party would be "standing on its own" in the Lok Sabha election.

In Kerala, the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) and the CPI(M)-led Left Democratic Front (LDF) have a long history of intense rivalry. The LDF has been in power for two consecutive terms, while the Congress swept the last Lok Sabha election, winning 15 of the 20 seats. Both sides have already announced that INDIA will not be a functional entity in the southern state, where the BJP has been attempting to make inroads.

The friction between the two parties was evident during the parliamentary meeting on December 5. In response to an adjournment notice given by Lok Sabha MP and PCC chief K. Sudhakaran decrying the law and order situation in the state, CPI(M) floor leader Elamaram Kareem said that differences at the state level should not be dragged to the Centre. But his words had little impact, as minutes later, Congress MP Jebi Mather raised the issue of a Kerala farmer's suicide, allegedly because of delays in payment of paddy subsidies by the state government.

Occasionally, the Congress has been accommodative of the demands of allies. For instance, in July, the party decided to oppose the controversial central ordinance that denied the Kejriwal government a final say in the transfer and postings of bureaucrats in the national capital. By doing this, the Congress high command went against its Delhi unit, which did not want to be seen as being on the same page as AAP. In fact, the Congress remains non-committal on seat-sharing primarily because of opposition from state units, which feel that yielding constituencies will further diminish the party in these areas.

Such skirmishes are likely to emerge in states where existing coalitions are at work. In Bihar, the JD(U) and Lalu Yadav's Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) will drive a hard bargain and are unlikely to leave even five seats for the